loosely translated as ‘Let knowledge shine’. In the form that has come down to us it is made up of 1028 *sukta*s, or hymns, organised into ten books. Every hymn is directed at a named god – not the gods of Hinduism as we know them today but two kinds of deities: benevolent *deva*s, who were entirely abstract; and the often hostile gods they called *asura*s, who were elemental. Many of these deities they shared with their first- and second-cousins further to the west. A tablet from central Turkey carries the names of the gods Indra, Mitra and Varuna as guarantors of a peace treaty drawn up between the Hittites and the Egyptians in about 1400 BCE. All three are among the most powerful of the Vedic gods: the *deva* Mitra is the binder of contracts and social order, as well as being a sun-god; the *asura* Varuna began as the most powerful of the elemental gods, associated with water and rain, but was gradually eclipsed by his rival Indra, the thunderbolt-wielding lord of heaven, to whom a quarter of the hymns of the *R-V* (289 in number) are directed. Next in popularity comes Agni, god of fire, to whom 218 hymns are directed.

Vishnu and Shiva, so dominant in later centuries, are all but insignificant to the early Arya. Vishnu merits six hymns in the *R-V* while Shiva is entirely absent under that name, although part of his multifarious character lurks there as Rudra, ‘the howler’, god of wind. What is also apparent is that the composers of the *R-V* had no time for the worship of Shiva in his prime form, the linga, since linga-worship is unequivocally condemned in the *R-V*.[16] This injunction points to linga-worship already being an established local practice, seemingly as shocking to the Arya as it appeared to the Victorians three thousand years later.

The *R-V* is a compilation of hymns assembled over centuries, with additions and interpolations. The earliest are identifiable by their more archaic language – an archaism that has obvious linguistic links with the sacred texts of